

Rubinstein, who became a major influence. Among Tchaikovsky's promising early works was an overture, *The Storm*, based on Alexander Ostrovsky's play, and a choral setting of Friedrich Schiller's poem "Ode to Joy."

Tchaikovsky moved to Moscow in 1866, having been offered a teaching post at the Moscow Conservatory by its director, Nikolai Rubinstein, brother of Anton, who championed his works and introduced him into the city's musical and intellectual circles. In 1868, Rubinstein conducted the premiere of Tchaikovsky's *Symphony No. 1* ("Winter Dreams"); by this time, Tchaikovsky was hard at work on his first opera, *The Voyevoda*.

In 1869, the composer Mily Balakirev suggested Tchaikovsky should create an orchestral work based on *Romeo and Juliet* by Shakespeare; the piece premiered in 1870, but was then revised twice, reaching its final form in 1880 (which premiered in 1886). In it, Tchaikovsky achieves a synthesis of Western structure and Russian idiom: the theme linked with Friar Laurence (a monk of Renaissance Verona) is unmistakably in the musical language of the Russian Orthodox Church.

Meanwhile, Tchaikovsky's personal life was strewn with tragedy. Over the years, he had relationships with a number of younger men, sometimes his pupils and, later, his own nephew. While writing *Romeo and Juliet*, he was involved with a Conservatory student, Eduard Sack, who committed suicide in 1873. Tchaikovsky wrote: "It seems to me that I have never loved anyone so strongly as him ... and his memory is sacred to me!"

New influences awaited Tchaikovsky in 1876. Visiting Paris, he attended Georges Bizet's new opera *Carmen*; its Fate motif